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Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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CHAPTER V c. 1904-1907 A GIRL'S FIRST MARRIAGE ()

*Save my life, hankaka, save my life,
Save my life, hankaka, save my life
On the day of marriage;
Save my life, hankaka, save my life,
Bazara has come,
Hankaka with the white breast,
White-breasted one, marriage has come .*

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The bride wants hankaka, the pied crow, to rescue her, so that they shall not give her in marriage. There are a lot of people in the compound, the younger sister of the bride's mother, her mother's mother, all her friends and the drummers and praise-singers and onlookers; they are all inside the compound, unless it is a house where the women are secluded, in which case they would only come as far as the forecourt. The young men, the bridegroom's friends, come, and his younger brother (the bride's joking relation) they come and help to hold her. Some of the girls, and the bride's younger sister, go over to the bridegroom's compound, if it is his first marriage too they will be putting henna on him; (⁹⁸) he has a *mawankiya*, his mother's younger sister. When the henna has been put on, the drummers drum and the girls play, there is dancing—even the bride joins in. The young men from the bridegroom's compound and the village come and watch. When it is time to eat their food, the girls go into a hut and close the door, so that the young men can't come and take away their food.

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The bride stays in her *mawankiya's* compound for four nights; *mawankiya* puts henna on the bride's arms and legs every day, and ties them up in leaves, but she doesn't put the long henna-gourd on  91 her hand and arm, so the girl just unties the leaves and pulls them off and runs off to play. When the girls cook food in *mawankiya's* compound they give some to the drummers and singers.

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This is the only occasion known to me on which all **Hausa** males are stained with henna.

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